

The Hive

Lying in the chilly dusk beneath the tree could have been a welcome respite for Garrett, under other circumstances. But such as they were – rapidly dropping temperature, the sticky clammy mess of blood freezing in the snow under his head, and a complete lack of understanding as to where on the mountain he was – Garrett fought his addled, sluggish brain to conclude that he was in dire straits and that staying put would have been one more poor decision in a long chain of poor decisions he had made in the last twenty-four hours.

He struggled to sit up but couldn't raise his torso from the deep drift of snow beneath the low drooping branches of the tree. A space of darkling evergreen boughs offered room for his head, but something held him down. He relaxed from his initial effort and returned his head to the cool cradle that had formed in the snow under him, trying to recall how he had gotten here. He must have taken a fall, but the details didn't immediately fill in. Distracted by his lack of mobility, he decided to take stock of his body instead. He started with his toes. He felt he was wiggling them, although he couldn't be sure. The tightness of his ski boots caused some numbness, so the perception of movement was all he could get. A dull pain issued from his right knee, but by flexing his calf, pivoting his foot up and down and side to side against the inside of the stiff boot, he thought probably that the ski on that foot had not come off and that the weight of the ski was holding his foot at an angle that was twisting his knee. He rotated his left foot freely, and feeling no resistance, he lifted the boot into the air between two close tree limbs, relieved in a detached way that the extremity he was feeling was in fact visible, apparently unharmed, and under his control. He understood that no ski was there and that

he'd need to find it, but the understanding drifted by as if borne by the stiffening breeze and was filed back among things to deal with soon but not now.

Now the hands. He wiggled his fingers. No pain there. They remained relatively warm in the Gore-Tex gloves he had worn for a half-dozen seasons. He then turned and pivoted his wrists, finding that his arms were cradling something hard against his chest like a laborer might carry a stack of two-by-fours. His goggles prevented his seeing his own chest, but with his gloved hands he was able to feel the object to learn its identity. The lost ski, he realized, and his two ski poles, were stacked parallel across his chest, and looking left and right, he saw that the equipment was securely jammed among the low boughs of the fir tree, its foliage partly buried in the drift, effectively pinning him against the snow. This fact came as a relief, since he was apparently not paralyzed, which had been his first fear upon being unable to sit up. Never mind that lifting his entire foot was proof of spinal health. People are never paralyzed from the waist up. But the cogs in Garrett's cranium weren't clicking away at full speed, and this kind of logic was not at the moment available to him. So he moved through this process of self-assessment with the aid only of impulse. Had he not received a powerful blow to the face and head, he might have detected the faint smell of his own blood amidst the clean overpowering scent of pine sap and needles. But he had just made a positive double-discovery, which made him smile a bloody gap-toothed grin at his fortune. Finding lost skis in deep snow can take a long time. And being paralyzed was just sucky all the way around, even in the shelter and warmth of your own home. Being paralyzed and lost in the snow on a Colorado mountain was just about the same as being dead already. So he enjoyed this relief for a moment. He hadn't really assessed his head anyway. He would determine in

time, by opening and closing his jaw, swiveling his head, working the muscles of his face and forehead, and feeling around in his mouth with his tongue, that he was missing some teeth and that the beating lump of pain on his brow probably meant a solid goose egg had formed from contact with the tree he now languished under.

His body check complete, the intention of getting the heck out of there, which had occurred to him upon waking in uncertain wisps of good sense, returned with more urgency, and he sought to disentangle the ski and poles from the branches and alleviate the pressure on his knee. This procedure took a few minutes. He realized the sun was already behind the ridge and felt its waning effect in the air. A soft icy breeze whispered of the coming night. The whispering may have been telling him to give up. *Curl up in the drift and let it happen.* It was a fine idea, really. If he had given the idea a chance, he might have concurred, but his dumb body struggled with the process of freedom as if under no direction from his mind, as if there wasn't really a choice. If he had made a choice, he might have decided to just curl into a ball and give up, thus dying of exposure in the sub-freezing night. That would have been the end of that long chain of poor decisions, the end of Garrett.

In short, Garrett was deprived of sleep, high as a bat, and probably suffering from a concussion. In the few minutes he spent extricating himself from the tree and detaching his right ski, he wasn't able to collect all these facts into concise summary or to recall how he ended up in this predicament in the first place. But we have more time than he did, so let's start from the beginning of the day.

It was a Wednesday, and he had planned to attend his Western Civ class that afternoon, in which he had a major assignment due. His studies at the University of Colorado at Denver were floundering somewhat, but the previous evening had doomed an already teetering performance in this semester's class. He had some other sophomore level general core classes that met on Wednesday, but he was studiously avoiding any real investment in them and had found he could skip class occasionally with no ill effect on his prospects of passing. Most of his energy was focused on his freedom, with occasional spurts of productivity to keep his grades in passing range. Between the hours of one and two in the morning, while he was polishing up a paper and preparing to print it for class the next afternoon, a hard-drive crash put his laptop into blue-screen lockdown. He lost the entire project and some other notes he had made since his last backup, and he realized in the wee hours that there was no solution available. The impending failure produced a flurry of mixed emotions ranging from destructive rage to helpless despair, and he determined between his first and second beer that the day, and possibly the semester, was shot anyway. So his next move was the first of the day's poor decisions. He picked up the phone and dialed Scott Vogel.

He could hear his father's comments echoing as if on a loop as he punched Vogel's digits on his iPhone. "You need to stay away from that Vogel kid, Garrett. He's no good. You've got to soar with the eagles, not run with the turkeys. We are just a product of our decisions. One poor decision always leads to another. You've got to make better choices." These comprised the theme of his father's communication with him in the last few years, mostly at the end of high school, when it became apparent that, between his father's ambitions of Garrett earning a degree and the much more meager

ambitions of Scott Vogel to spend quality time near the slopes of Vail, waxing skis or teaching lessons, Garrett was aiming somewhere in the middle. He had spent his first year at UC Denver darting up to the mountains at every possible opportunity, trying to keep from declaring a major so as to avoid a more serious commitment to his future. The announcement to his parents over the summer that he still had not declared was swallowed without overt confrontation. His mother made him eggs and bacon in the mornings and tried to make small talk with that stiff smile that screamed “I’m trying not to show my disappointment” and “I am thoroughly disappointed” all at once. His father simply waxed philosophical, never broaching the subject of his major, but directing his musings toward Garrett’s ill-chosen relationship with Vogel or more generally toward the kind of self-help inspirational bull crap that streamed out of the speakers of his car from so many personal development programs and self-improvement audio-books. “Don’t settle for second best.” “Whether you decide you can or you can’t, you’re always right.” Or “Only accept excellence from yourself. Nothing else will do.”

Garrett popped open a can of Monster sports drink, or “liquid crack” as he liked to call it, while Vogel’s line rang. He considered napping for a few hours and driving later, but having made the decision, as poor as his father might say it was, he was determined to make the most of the day.

Vogel’s sleepy voice finally croaked at the other end, “Whaaaaaat.”

“Hey, you working today?” Garrett asked.

“No, was planning on sleeping some more, making a few turns, but...dude, you know it’s three, right?”

“Good. I’m coming up there.” He slurped some Monster, willing the caffeine to hurry and do its work. “You up for a little shroom and zoom?”

“Well, yeah, but you’ve got some driving to do first. Let me sleep and we’ll get it together when you get here. Go slow. Vail Pass got another dump yesterday; it’ll be plowed by now, but it’ll still be dicey. Door’s unlocked.”

Garrett started to comment that the storm over Vail Pass meant some fresh powder, but the connection had already clicked closed.

Almost three hours later, in the bracing cold of predawn, Garrett let himself into Vogel’s dingy pad, amped on several Monster drinks and ready to ride. He jammed a knee into Vogel’s shoulder where he lay on the couch, his arm flung out over the cluttered floor, cell phone lying directly under his hand where he had dropped it after closing out his call.

“Wake up, Vogel. I’m here. It’s on, it’s on! Blue Sky Basin’s waiting for us.” He hopped giddily on the balls of his feet, cruising on caffeine and the torrential flood of adrenaline that always comes from driving on hard-packed snow, darting between big rigs. Vogel stirred and then sat up, ruffled his matted brown hair, scratched an armpit, blinked a few times and then burst into motion. He was a dedicated snow-boarder. His entire existence revolved around boarding. Surrounded by evidence of a complete lack of ambition – empty beer cans, millions of Dorito crumbs, pizza boxes and Ramen noodle packages – the young man sprang from a state of total rest to one of unbridled zeal. He was ambitious about riding the board. Garrett smiled. He knew he could count on Vogel to come through on short notice.

“Curly’s working the early shift at the Gondola. He’ll let us up and meet us later.”

He disappeared into a back room and reappeared in long johns with a backpack and an armload of clothing, which he swiftly jerked on, zipped up and Velcroed. He put a couple baggies in the backpack, threw in some water bottles, bananas and granola bars and held out one for Garrett. Garrett’s thumbs stayed tucked behind the straps of his own backpack. He shook his head.

“I’m stocked. Snacks, water, my favorite bowl, and my lucky Zippo. You got enough stuff for me, right?”

Vogel nodded curtly. “You don’t even have to ask, bro. We’re covered.”

Within thirty minutes they had gathered skis and board, secured them to the rack on Garrett’s car, drove across the sleepy white-blanketed town, parked in a public lot near the main lift, and schlepped the gear to the gondola house. After a quick exchange with the bleary-eyed, blond-haired lift operator, Curly, they were on their way up the mountain. Blue Sky Basin was a back-country area behind the main ridge of the resort. It took a determined effort to get there under normal morning conditions, and if a skier waited until the lifts officially opened and made his way across to the far end of the ridge at Two Elks Lodge, a monstrous restaurant at the extreme end of the resort, he was only halfway there. Plunging down the back bowls behind the front ridge and riding up the Blue Sky Express chairlift, he would get to that remote spot with barely a half-day of skiing remaining before the lifts started to shut down. But a resort of this size required hundreds of personnel to operate each lift area, restaurant lodge, groomer, and ski patrol station, and these people needed to be in place before the first paying customers appeared on the mountain. Knowing the majority of these workers, especially those at the lifts,

enabled Garrett and Vogel to ride up and get out to Blue Sky with ample time to get a whole day in on the Basin's gladed acreage. The workers would recognize them at a glance and then simply turn their heads as they mounted each successive lift. The sun was rising as they rode the gondola, and by the time they reached the Basin and rode the chair up once, the morning was fully realized, and successive lifts to the top would be during regular operating hours. The sky had cleared from the previous day's storm, and the pristine morning showed them thousands of tons of untracked powder. Vogel punched Garrett on the arm, his wide yellow grin spreading under the lower rim of his mirrored goggles.

"This is going to be a good one, man," he said. "I don't know why you ditched school, but I sure am glad you did." As wrong as Vogel was in his prediction, at that moment Garrett couldn't have agreed more.

The morning unfolded like a snow junkie's fondest wish. It was perfect. They made some turns, rode back up, made some more, stopped midslope to smoke some pot and get a snack, and then kept on, finding new fields of powder, gliding and laughing loudly at their good fortune. Later in the morning, they shared the vast fields of white with scattered skiers and snowboarders – people who had come across the ridge at the normal opening time.

Both young men were expert in their skills, and picking through a dense snow-jammed forest or a field of steep moguls had long lost its thrill. As many extreme sports did, this one thrived on the progression through mounting levels of difficulty, until skiers or boarders of that caliber had a choice to heighten the excitement: they could sink thousands of dollars, which neither of these men had, into helicopter drops onto ultra-

remote peaks, or they could get impaired by dropping acid, pounding shots, or any other number of medicinal routes to the same end and ski normal accessible terrain with a different outlook on things. Vogel preferred the magic mushroom because it somehow appealed to his appreciation of nature's simplicity. Curly would join them soon to provide that enhancement. Scooting down the runs while things shifted around, took on exaggerated appearances, or appeared out of thin air was a joy, no chemistry required. Alcohol slowed his reactions, so that wasn't his bag. For now, they combined the morning's runs with a steady intake of marijuana, another naturalist's delight, just to establish a baseline of mellowness before the afternoon runs.

They stopped at the lodge atop the Blue Sky Basin at midday and had magnificent bowls of meaty chili with all the fixings. They sipped water to fend off the dehydration that goes with high-altitude exertion and took turns laughing at each other's stupid grins. The seating area consisted of two dozen round tables, about half of them occupied with skiers and boarders, taking a quick break from the easy work of sliding through creamy drifts of powder. Gloves, goggles, helmets, and backpacks dripped with newly melted snow in the center of the tables, surrounded by knots of people chatting, eating and drinking, enjoying easy company. A lanky blond with a bright red parka and baggy grey snowboard pants eased up to Garrett and Vogel's table.

"Room for one more?" he asked, sitting down with his tray.

"Curly!" Vogel slapped him on the shoulder.

"Hey, man, you ready?" Garrett asked and laughed.

"Yeah, easy shift today. I'd say the stars are lining up for a helluva day, huh.

Garrett's back, snow's deep, and I brought the good stuff."

“Right on,” Garrett said. “I’ve got a fat bowl with your name on it, too.” They laughed. The compact glass pipe Garrett kept for personal use was a hand-me-down from Curly last year. It actually had Curly’s name printed across the stem in Sharpie ink. Ever since marijuana was decriminalized in Colorado, the possession of paraphernalia such as this was commonplace and more than tolerated. Putting one’s name on a pipe didn’t seem to be such a stupid way to keep track of one’s effects anymore. Radio stations were advertising smoke shops at regular airtimes, “for all your glassware and cannabis needs.”

“Well, thanks for the offer, but I came stocked, so it’s all good,” Curly said.

The young men shared a knowing laugh at such outstanding prospects for a wonderful half-day of bliss.

The afternoon went by even more smoothly than the morning, now with three riders, stopping occasionally for a hit before continuing the search for remaining untracked powder. They ate mushrooms and washed down the turd-flavored sponges with water. By the end of the day, Garrett had lost track of his intake. They lifted up a last time, and, looking out over the Rockies stretched for miles under the slanting sun, they agreed it was time to catch the lift up the backside before it closed for the day. Garrett clicked off his skis and yelled for them to go on. He had to take a quick piss before the trek to the bottom. He’d catch them somewhere on the predetermined route to the Lion’s Head village, or he would see them at the pub there for a quick dinner to close out the day. This was their custom. They didn’t question whether he could or would make it. They slid off down the hill. After peeing, Garrett returned to his skis, knocked the loose snow off his boots and clicked his right boot into the binding. It clacked firmly into place, and he leaned onto his right pole to do the same on the left side. He was at

that moment considering how many seasons he had ridden on these trusty old skis, after buying them used from a rental shop in the village, when he forced his left boot down against the clamping mechanism and the ancient binding fell apart with an ugly metallic crack. Now here was another momentous decision. A reasoning adult would have collected his equipment and walked back to the lodge and asked for transport from one of the ski patrol guys with a snowmobile, and he'd have had a quick gas-powered ride back to Lion's Head without incident. This watershed moment didn't catch Garrett in a state of clear-headed reasoning, however, and he made the next in that chain of poor decisions. His thought process went something like:

Can I get all the way back on one ski? There's a challenge. I've heard of really good skiers doing it when they had to. I'm good enough. It'll be tricky, but I can do it.

In this way the challenge before him became more interesting than a hundred-yard tromp to the nearest snowmobile, and the choice put Garrett into prime position for misfortune to unfold. His invincible nineteen-year-old mind, even fogged with Vogel and Curly's natural substances, considered the odds and concluded that they were in his favor. And they were in his favor, as good of a skier as he was. But what he didn't consider was the consequences of an unimagined failure, the lottery ticket with the disastrous jackpot. He put the pieces of his ruined binding into his backpack, clutched the ski and his two poles across his body and headed down the hill. Within a quarter mile of awkward turns on the alternating edges of his right ski, he misjudged a patch of heavy snow, lurched off-balance into the tree line and simply tried to keep upright and shoot for gaps between the giant snow-laden firs in his path. He picked up more speed as the slope fell away, teetering on the one right leg, shifting his weight forcibly to change edges, the terrain and

random spacing between trees shepherding him ever farther from the marked terrain.

After an undetermined distance, he was not able to keep up with the increasing speed of the slalom, and he eventually careened into a large fir tree with a whump and an explosion of fluffy powder. The silent looming firs and the pure billowing drifts muffled the brutality of his sudden stop.

This was how Garrett came to be in this place, in this condition, under these unhappy circumstances. Standing next to the fragrant evergreen, now bereft of its former load of snow, gingerly feeling the knot and gash on his head, leaning against the skis and poles hooked upright in his left arm, Garrett was ill-equipped to make a sound decision on how best to escape his predicament. Escape he must, he knew that much. But he now stood in a glade in the shadow of the ridge, so his sense of direction was confounded. He didn't remember much about the moments preceding the crash, he wasn't sure how long he had been unconscious, and his head swam with a combination of trauma, chemicals and fatigue. He fished in his breast pocket for his iPhone and found it shattered beyond any kind of functionality. It had been smashed against the ski he was cradling in his arms. A sensible reaction would have been to follow his own tracks back up the hill to where he had entered the forest and hope for a passing patrol or at least move toward the lift and try for a callbox. But as his father had warned, one poor decision can unleash a whole avalanche of others, and he wasn't in a proper state for sensible reactions. His mind's only instruction to his body was to keep moving, and in obedience he forged off in the direction of least resistance, straight downhill.

It was nearly fully dark when he fell into a deep drift next to a bristling wall of roots where a massive tree had fallen. A brittle network of roots beneath him cracked and gave way, and he fell through and slid for what seemed an impossible distance, landing abruptly on hard-packed earth in the pitch black. An electric pain shot up his spine from the landing, and his ears buzzed and rang in the now ultimate silence of this subterranean domain.

Garrett's senses at this moment were attuned to a unique and amplified array of channels, and his brain's ability to interpret the input was skewed at best. What happened in these next moments would have made for a fascinating tale over beers when he returned, but as it turned out he would never be able to sort out what was real from what was imagined, and none of it made any sense in retrospect. Certain details, including the simple fact of his presence on the mountain that night, would have even been incriminating, and so when he got back to civilization – and he did make it back – he wouldn't utter a word of it to anyone. Mostly, it was simply unbelievable. He himself wasn't sure if it was an authentic set of experiences or some kind of wicked dream. So he decided it was better to just keep it to himself, where the images and sounds would eventually jumble and cloud over. Years later, he would have trouble putting the impressions into any kind of cogent system. Whether his silence was another poor decision or a wise one, he would never know. Here is what he experienced:

Profound blackness. He waved a hand in front of his face and saw not the faintest change in shade. The movement of his hand wafted an oppressive, putrid odor into his nostrils, so thick he felt it sticking to his face. He seemed to hear, under the persistent buzzing of nothingness, the faintest creak of his irises stretching to their utmost limits to

allow any available light onto his retinas. Blood, pine and earth mingled on his tastebuds with a barely perceptible undertaste of banana, granola, chili, mushrooms, and even the faint hint of weed, the smoke of which clung to the roof of his mouth. His butt tingled in partial numbness where he had impacted the uneven solid earth, and his lumpy head throbbed with the heightened pace of his heartbeat.

He slid his backpack off, realizing that he no longer held his skis or poles, which must have become lodged across the earthen chute through which he had fallen and slid. He unzipped the pack and thrust his arm in, feeling around the objects within. He remembered a game he had played in kindergarten in which each student would reach into a large felt bag and attempt to identify the contents by touch alone. He had an edge in this game, since he had packed this bag himself. His mind itemized the objects as his fingers encountered them: *four pieces of shitty old Rossignol ski binding, three oats and honey granola bars, one smashed banana, two banana peels, one glass marijuana bowl marked Curly, one-and-a-half bottles of Deer Park spring water, one chocolate chip cookie from the Blue Sky Lodge, and aha! one trusty Zippo.*

Garrett pulled his fist out of the pack and clicked open the Zippo's cover. He heard the whispering escape of butane before he pulled his thumb down on the rasping wheel, and the earthy space was illuminated in a dazzling flame. The cave assaulted his eyes with a profusion of tangled roots, earth and sludge, scattered bones and rocks. He saw an enormous heap of what seemed to be matted fur rising and falling with a slow patient rhythm in the furthest reaches of the burrow (that's what it must have been, a burrow). What appeared to be dozens of mice, or some other tiny creatures, darted and hopped into shadows, beady black-pearl eyes reflecting back the glare of his Zippo like

paired pinpricks of starlight. In the few seconds it took to apprehend the scene, he became aware of the sound of his own panicked breathing and the sound of a slower, cavernous respiration. Then an eye opened in the deep shadow at the distant end of the furry heap and a growling, wheezing voice said, "Put it out, stranger." He obeyed.

The cave was plunged back into blackness, but the negative image of the flame and the hulking form lingered stubbornly on his retinas and began to merge into a creature of what must have been his own imaginative design. For there was no longer light to see, and what should have remained was a static image. But the afterimage was not static. The heap moved and shifted its bulk, and new waves of putrescence wafted over him. The pinpricks of light also continued to move, and more of these glimmering pairs emerged from the dark void, hovering around the bulky form, which now had two burning fire-blue eyes like gas jets from a stove. As he sat transfixed, the many pinprick eyes began to develop bodies, not of rodents but of tiny bipeds. Each hopped and danced and hovered around the larger creature like satellites around a planet, and he realized that some were hovering with the aid of wings blurred in motion. The buzzing sound swelled as more of these tiny men took wing and flitted around under the low ceiling. One buzzed at his head but stopped short and hovered there, inches before his wide eyes. It was two inches in height, and had clammy gray skin over spindly limbs with knobby joints. The mouth was wide, holding countless needle teeth, and the head was flat. The flat skull, in its similarity to a Homo Sapien precursor like Homo Erectus or Cro-Magnon man, would have implied stupidity if not for the piercing eyes, which warned of a much more sinister intelligence. The creature buzzed back to its hulking master and floated near its ear. It spoke with no apparent intent to avoid being heard.

“It seems a host has brought himself to us, my queen,” the tiny man said.

“So it seems,” the deeper voice replied.

“Shall we accept this invitation?” another flitting drone asked.

“What is your purpose?” the queen answered. Her gas-jet eyes flickered.

“To serve you, queen. To sow mischief, ill-nature, discord,” one shouted.

“Destruction!” squealed another.

“Death!” said the first, who had flown back to within an inch of Garrett’s nose.

Garrett flinched from the creature, and from the word.

“Will this host serve your purpose?” said the hulking figure. Her form shifted, now like a bear, now like a troll, then like a great cat.

“He smells of confusion,” the first little man said and flicked out a webbed foot, tapping Garrett on the tip of his nose. He blinked at the contact and blinked again hard, trying to dispel the swirling images of this impossible vision. The images remained. He sat, paralyzed. His stomach clenched and his genitals retreated in vestigial preparation for a fight or flight that he had no courage to launch. He felt like a wide-eyed rabbit, who will freeze in the face of eminent danger as if to hide in plain sight, even while his ears reported the proof of his detection. Clammy sweat tickled the small of his back.

“You are too particular about the host’s state of mind, Beezle,” said the next nearest creature. “When we are in full control, their confusion doesn’t matter. All the better. If he is confused, he can’t as easily interfere. As your ability improves, you can overcome interference altogether. Queen, with your permission, I would like the privilege. I have just the task in mind for him, and it will mean much destruction, maybe some death.” He zoomed closer, leering a thin-lipped smile.

“Very well,” the wheezing hulk replied. “Do your worst.”

“I will,” said the second creature and flitted around behind Garrett’s head where he could no longer see him. The buzzing from the single creature grew impossibly loud, and Garrett felt it alight faintly on his ear. He wouldn’t remember the pain that followed, quick and exquisite, before his vision completely failed and he lost consciousness.

Garrett awoke in his car around midnight. He still wore his ski clothes, minus his boots, which he saw lying on the snow under the yellow glow of the parking area lights. His backpack lay on the seat next to him. His breath billowed into the car’s frigid interior. He opened the door and retrieved the boots, and the dome light stayed on long enough to reveal the grisly mess of his face looking back at him in the mirror. He was crusted and smeared with dried blood, the gash on his head was packed with earth, the knot was receding but an angry purple, and the outer edges of his ears were blackening with frostbite. Some of the hairs on his forehead and eyebrows were singed. He couldn’t feel some of his toes. These he would lose to frostbite as well, but he reckoned it an acceptable loss, considering. He cranked his car and thought of going to Vogel’s and letting him know he was okay, but he didn’t want to try to recall his evening or explain his condition. He couldn’t account for the last eight hours, anyway. He wanted to get back to Denver, regroup, try to make some sense of it and start putting it behind him right away. He would find a phone and call Vogel when he got there. What was the difference between letting him know at three a.m. or five a.m.?

He cranked the fan, willing the engine to warm quickly so the restorative heat could begin thawing out his icy bones. He wasn't sure he'd ever be truly warm again. His stomach convulsed in horrible shivers, making his breath ragged and labored.

As he motored along I-70 passing the eastern part of Vail, his gaze was attracted by hundreds of lights, snowmobiles and snowcats, streaming up the side of the mountain toward the far end of the ridge. What he glimpsed there stunned him so completely that he pulled into the emergency lane and stared up the dark slope of the mountain. A fire rose there, impossibly high, seeming to lick the stars and the moon. Two Elks Lodge was fully involved in a bonfire the likes of which he had never seen. Even after the images from the burrow became cloudy and jumbled and untrusted, the image of that destruction would remain forever in his heart as the secret symbol of an unnamed dread.

THE END